

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

A CAUSE FOR CONGRESS
SP leader Azam Khan with his son Abdulla Azam

Telangana. That 'wave' of optimism has now evidently reached as far afield as UP. Party leaders speak of a revival of its old Muslim-Dalit-Brahmin vote-bank ahead of 2024.

For starters, the party is wooing and bringing on board Muslim leaders, working on a list of desirable targets in the SP and BSP. "We are focusing on those who have not got the respect they deserve in their parties. We are concentrating on Azam Khan because we feel issues pertaining to him have not been raised properly by the SP. His family has been suffering a huge atrocity for several years, but the SP did not raise its voice proportionately," a Congress leader says.

Asked if the move wouldn't irk the SP further—the two INDIA bloc allies recently had a falling-out over seat-sharing in neighbouring Madhya Pradesh—Rai feigns normalcy. "It shouldn't," he says. "This is a good thing for INDIA. But we can't say why (SP chief) Akhilesh Yadav has not met him (Azam Khan) so far." On his part, Akhilesh barely kept his cool. "Everyone should meet Azam Khan. But where was the Congress when he was being framed? They were busy framing him," he says. With the MP spat fresh in everyone's minds, this doesn't augur well for the alliance. Undeterred, the Congress is going beyond just one show of solidarity: a senior party leader hints at several programmes where they would demand Azam Khan's release.

GROUND PLAN

- **By showing solidarity with Azam Khan, Congress is wooing Muslims in UP before the 2024 LS polls**
- **Two West UP leaders, Imran Masood and Ahmad Hameed, joined Congress in October**
- **The party will start a campaign for Dalit-Muslim unity soon**

In western UP—the 10-time Rampur MLA's extended home base—several influential Muslim leaders have either joined the Congress or are tipped to cross over after the results of the five assembly elections are out in December, the leader adds. In early October, former MLA Imran Masood, who wields some influence in Saharanpur and nearby areas, returned to the Congress after spending time in the SP and BSP. Ahmad Hameed, son of late Congress leader Kaukab Hameed Khan, also joined the Congress from the Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD). Also, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi recently met Danish Ali, the BSP MP from Amroha who was subjected to abusive language during the Women's Reservation Bill debate in Parliament.

Over the past three decades, the Congress has watched its Muslim votes in UP gravitate towards the SP, which was formed in 1992. Breaking out of its resigned air, the Grand Old Party hopes to reverse that trend. According to Shilp Shikha Singh, political analyst and assistant professor at Lucknow's Giri Institute of Development Studies, "The Congress believes Muslims prefer them over regional parties in Lok Sabha polls, so they are focusing on them. In the past, too, we have seen this broad trend."

Shahnawaz Alam, Congress minority cell chief, tells INDIA TODAY that other plans, too, have been chalked out for Muslims. "From November 6 to 11, we are launching 'Congress ki baat / Chai ke saath' (Talk about the Congress with a cup of tea). For this, we will organise public meetings in minority-dominated areas. We will talk about why leadership has been destroyed in the past two decades in the state. We will also raise the issue of Azam Khan. Later, we will tell them what Congress governments have done for them in the past." A campaign for Dalit-Muslim unity will be started in the latter part of November, says Alam. "The Congress is the only party that has taken a genuine stand on issues related to Muslims. Whether it is anti-CAA protests or atrocities against Muslim leaders, Congress has always taken a strong stand." SP spokesperson Fakrul Hasan Chand makes light of the Congress plans. "Muslims support SP and they vote for us in the assembly polls. Congress is just dreaming that they will come to them. Let them dream, we know the reality," he says. ■